

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 1321

Culture (OWC): [Luguru \(FN32\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1959-1960

Coverage Date: 1959 AD - 1960 AD

Place Coverage

Uluguru Mountains, Morogoro Region, Tanzania

Section Title(S): SOCIAL OBLIGATIONS

Watani also participate in ceremonies (*tambiko*) at the grave of the deceased, one held a month or two after burial and another several months later. A mtani will carry the beer used to pour a libation to the deceased and the ancestors, and watani also have the duty of clearing the grave of weeds and grass. During the prayers to the clan ancestors the watani may rebuke or coerce the dead, saying "You who have died, do not come back and cause trouble for the living," or they may admonish the elders to carry out the ceremony in the prescribed manner so as not to offend the ancestors. **Joking** may enter in here again, for when the names of ancestors are mentioned that a mtani does not recall, he may enquire "Who are they?" If the clan members are having difficulty remembering the names of ancestors to mention, a mtani may say: "What is the matter with you, do you not know the names of your ancestors?"

[602
Kin Relationships](#)
[764
Burial Practices And
Funerals](#)
[769
Cult Of The Dead](#)
[782
Prayers And Sacrifices](#)

One finds watani constantly cropping up as arbitrators of a dispute or officiants at some ceremony. For example, in the ritual where blood-brotherhood is established between two friends, a mtani of each has a role, as do watani in the propitiation of the ancestral spirits when a case of incest has been exposed involving members of the same clan. When the estate of a man is settled, they oversee the distribution and adjudicate any dispute that may arise.

[602
Kin Relationships](#)
[608
Artificial Kin
Relationships](#)
[626
Social Control](#)
[684
Sex And Marital
Offenses](#)
[769
Cult Of The Dead](#)

Another traditional practice where watani played a role was in cases of infanticide, where “unlucky” or “dangerous” children, known as *kigego*, were put to death. Examples of *kigego* would be one of twins, albinos, extreme anomalies evident at birth, or a breech presentation. The job of dispatching these neonates fell to one of the female watani present at the birth, usually a sister or mother of the husband. While infanticide is still admitted to occur today, particularly in the case of extreme anomalies, it is declining, and it is not uncommon to see twins. In one area there was a practice of giving some *kigego*, such as a child that cut the upper teeth first, to the wantani clan for adoption.

178
Sociocultural Trends

682
Offenses Against Life

845
Difficult And Unusual Births

847
Abortion And Infanticide

Duties that were not considered appropriate for the clan to perform, such as burial of someone who had died from leprosy or smallpox and the burning of his hut, were allocated to watani. Another duty was the removal of the fetus when a woman died with the child *in utero*. Senicide, or at least “expediting” the demise of individuals who were completely incontinent, in great pain, or insane to a degree where they constituted a menace, was reported as “done in the past.” Although this could be achieved by sheer neglect, where it required overt action, such as poison or strangulation, it should involve the watani. While infanticide was readily admitted and discussed, for obvious reasons⁷ it was more difficult to elicit information on senicide and what the Luguru regarded as mercy killing. While there was variation between districts as to duties and obligations of watani, one pattern did emerge—things that would be dangerous or distasteful to the clan could be carried out with impunity by watani without fear of retribution by the supernatural.

124
Interviewing In Research

165
Mortality

577
Ethics

614
Clans

753
Theory Of Disease

766
Special Burial Practices And Funerals

847
Abortion And Infanticide

888
Status And Treatment Of The Aged

⁷ In addition to a reluctance to discuss with a European something that was known to be against the law, senicide or mercy killing was apparently not common, and thus more difficult to analyze in terms of precedents. Unlike infanticide, where disposal of “unlucky” children had supernatural sanction, senicide or mercy killing did not. Another difficulty in eliciting information was that though the practice was regarded as necessary in some cases, it was viewed with repugnance by most Luguru, for it implied a negation of the tradition of high respect for the elders.

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries: ✉ hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs: ✉ hraf-support@yale.edu

[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)